justice system. We've always compromised. We've always cut deals. We've always left backdoors open. That's why Amir cannot not be forgiven. That's why he was given a chance to prove himself and make a comeback. And he has done so. Fabulously.

I tried to take care of Amir during the ban. I wanted to protect him. See, he never lied. He begged for forgiveness. He needed the protection. Salman, on the other hand, not only lied for years but also abused and blamed the team. He eventually relented. As captain, he should have accepted the blame. Moreover, he was educated. There was this whole myth built around him that Salman Butt is well-read, he's from a private school, he's better than us simpler, middle-class guys. We thought he was the real deal.

Unfortunately, ethics aren't learnt at school. We learn them at home. His ethics speak for himself. I'm not going after Salman Butt. I'm only pushing a larger concept – of what it means to be a Pakistan Test captain, the pinnacle of any Pakistani's cricketing career. And I'm issuing a warning again. What happened in England will happen again and again because we haven't taken hard, serious measures.

Thus, my one-line prediction about Salman's future prospects: there is no place for him in the team. Not in any team playing for the Islamic Republic of Pakistan.

As for Asif, he had other issues, too, besides those that *News of the World* exposed. Sure, he's got some mad skills with the new ball. I've never seen a better, more lethal new-ball fast bowler than him. That's my professional opinion. But you can go look up his off-the-field antics – from getting busted with drugs in Dubai to other errors, forced and unforced.

My take on the episode is simple. There was a leadership gap. Pakistan cricket has been in need of a captain since 1991. After Imran's – and maybe Wasim's – tenure, nobody has really, truly stepped up to take over. Imran's example is still cited almost thirty years after his retirement.

Why? Why can't we have a proper leader?

Why can't we have someone who will quell the politics? Someone who will stand his ground?

My only answer: the Pakistan Cricket Board.

You see, Imran Khan never had a proper team till he was allowed to make one by the board at the time. As captain, he was empowered by a board willing to put their trust in him. After all, it's the captain who has the most at stake when he leads his men on the field. Why not trust him? Why curb him? Why take his powers away?

They say that before he went to claim the crown in Australia in 1992, Imran was captaining *paratha*-chomping, mediocre street artists. But it was he who made them into a World Cup-winning unit because he had the authority to do so.

Meanwhile, I had spot-fixers and liars, thieves and robbers. Unfortunately, I had limited authority, an overbearing board and a second-guessing coach. By the time I put a good unit together, corruption hit my team. The squad went to the dogs soon after.

There is this narrative – that Pakistani players come from humble backgrounds and can't handle all the money and fame which comes their way when they hit international stardom. And it is believed that because they can't handle any of it, they either implode or go down the route of corruption and scandal. There's a counter to that narrative and it lies with the board, too.

The PCB shouldn't just be responsible for organizing tournaments and figuring out team selection. It should also be in charge of grooming players and preparing them for the real world.